Prime Readiness Map

Six gates between a capable shop and a defence buyer's order book. Which apply, where you stand, and who does the work. November 10, 2026.

Gate	What it is	Where you stand	What it takes	Who owns it
1. Registration	SAM.gov, UEI, CAGE code. Applies to any prime or government work.	To be established at discovery: registration status and CAGE code	Free. Half a day of someone's time; the CAGE code takes about ten business days. Renews yearly — a lapse takes you off the books.	You do it; we keep the renewal on the calendar.
2. Cybersecurity	NIST SP 800-171, SPRS, CMMC as the contract writes it. Applies to work involving controlled data, or when a prime asks.	To be established at discovery: where controlled data lives	Full controlled-data scope, from our effort table: shop IT 155–365 h; CGP + shop IT 60–140 h; owner 42–95 h; CGP 42–90 h. Scope decides the size: fifteen requirements for contract information, a hundred and ten for controlled data. Your IT provider configures; the records and evidence have no natural home.	Your IT provider configures; we run the records and the calendar.
3. Export control	ITAR registration with the State Department. Applies to munitions-list work, or its drawings.	To be established at discovery: whether your parts are on the munitions list, and whether a registration is on file	Renewed yearly, exporting or not. The real work is naming who owns it, with a backup, and controlling how drawings move.	You own the registration; we keep the record and the renewal date.
4. Quality	ISO 9001, AS9100, Nadcap, first-article records. Applies to when the buyer's quality requirements say so — most defence primes.	To be established at discovery: which certificates you hold, and when each expires	A certificate cycle runs in months, not weeks, and buyers check its scope. Special processes are accredited one at a time.	A registrar audits; your quality lead runs it; we keep it on the calendar.
5. Purchase order	The clauses on the order: CUI, counterfeit parts, traceability, specialty metals. Applies to every defence order.	To be established at discovery: the clauses your current orders carry, and whether melt origin is recorded	Paperwork per order, mill certificates tied to their lots — and melt origin settled before you quote, not after.	Your quality and purchasing people; we write the procedure.
6. Onboarding	The buyer's own supplier qualification. Applies to before the first order: questionnaire, site visit, approved supplier list.	To be established at discovery: which primes already have you on their supplier list	A capability and quality questionnaire, a day for a visit, and the buyer's own financial review.	You, with the file prepared for you.

A map, not an assessment. No certification or compliance is claimed. Costs, and who says so, are on the next page.

What each gate costs

Every figure carries who said it: **official** (a rule or a fee the government sets), **vendor estimate** (registrar or accreditation pricing — a band, not a quote), or **planning estimate** (ours, to check against a real provider).

Gate	What it costs	Class of figure	Where it comes from
1. Registration	Free. Nothing but attention, and about ten business days for the CAGE code to come back	official · 9 Nov 2026	SAM.gov registration guidance (SBA/GSA); CAGE assigned through SAM in about ten business days
2. Cybersecurity	Full controlled-data scope, by who does the work: shop IT 155–365 h; CGP + shop IT 60–140 h; owner 42–95 h; CGP 42–90 h. An assessment, if a contract calls for one, is a separate fee.	planning estimate	our own effort table, built from the NIST SP 800-171 catalogs
	It is also a doorway: the Joint Certification Program that lets a shop receive DLA technical data requires a NIST SP 800-171 assessment posted in SPRS, re-accomplished every three years, and it is phasing into a CMMC Level 2 certificate from a C3PAO between November 2025 and November 2028	official · 9 Nov 2026	DLA Joint Certification Program portal and JCP guide, July 2025
3. Export control	$3,000 a year at Tier 1 for a new registrant: $4,000 at Tier 2, $4,000 plus $1,100 per favourable determination at Tier 3. A qualifying Tier 1 registrant may petition for a $500 discount. The fee is annual whether or not the shop ever exports	official · 9 Nov 2026	DDTC registration fee tiers, ITAR 122.3(a), final rule 89 FR 99081 effective 9 January 2025
4. Quality	First year all in for a small shop with no quality system: about $15,000 to $50,000, split between implementation, consultancy and the audit. A shop that already holds ISO 9001 sits at the bottom of that	vendor estimate · 9 Nov 2026	2026 industry cost surveys for SMEs; small-org bands of $9,000 to $24,000 (under 25 staff, some QMS) and $30,000 to $80,000 (under 50 staff, implementation included)
	Months, not weeks, and nothing compresses it: 9 to 18 months for a machine shop with no quality system, 6 to 12 months from an existing ISO 9001	vendor estimate · 9 Nov 2026	2026 industry timelines; PRI recommends a six-month operating period before the audit
5. Purchase order	No published fee: the cost is per order. A written procedure, mill certificates tied to the lots they arrived with, and — the part that bites — sourcing settled before the quote, because where the metal was melted cannot be fixed mid-programme	industry estimate · 9 Nov 2026	DFARS specialty-metals and counterfeit-parts flow-downs (252.225-7009 and related); no published cost benchmark exists
6. Onboarding	Not priced anywhere, because the prime runs it: a capability and quality questionnaire, a site audit, its own financial review, and a place on its approved supplier list before a single order	no published figure · 9 Nov 2026	prime supplier-qualification processes; no published fee

None of this is a quote. No gate is required until a contract or the prime's own supplier requirements say so. Two are cheap: registering is free, and the government funds advisers for small suppliers — never pay for what is already free.

How the map gets filled in

Every row marked "to be established at discovery" is answered by a short discovery. Nothing is guessed.

What we need

- Who you sell to, and which of them ask about cybersecurity or export control.
- Whether any part you make is on the munitions list.
- The certificates you hold, with scope and expiry.
- Your last three defence purchase orders, to read the clauses.
- Who does your IT, and whether they would take on a documented scope.

What comes back

- This map, every row filled in, the ones that do not apply struck out.
- The order to take them in, with hours and cost for each.
- Who owns each one: you, your IT provider, a specialist, or us.

Fee. Fixed, agreed in writing before work starts, and the same whether or not a loan is ever made. The number is in the engagement letter.

This is the map before discovery. Once filled in, it carries the shop's own position.